



Freedom of Speech & Hate Speech

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I may disagree with what you say,
but I will defend to the death your
right to say it.

~ Voltaire



Voices Through Time

Definition

- The power or right to express one's opinions without censorship, restraint, or legal penalty.
- Enables democratic participation—allows individuals to challenge authority, share dissenting views, and shape public policy.



Greece

➤ **Parrhesia in Ancient Greece:**

Citizens had a civic duty to speak openly in the Athenian agora, challenging leaders without fear.

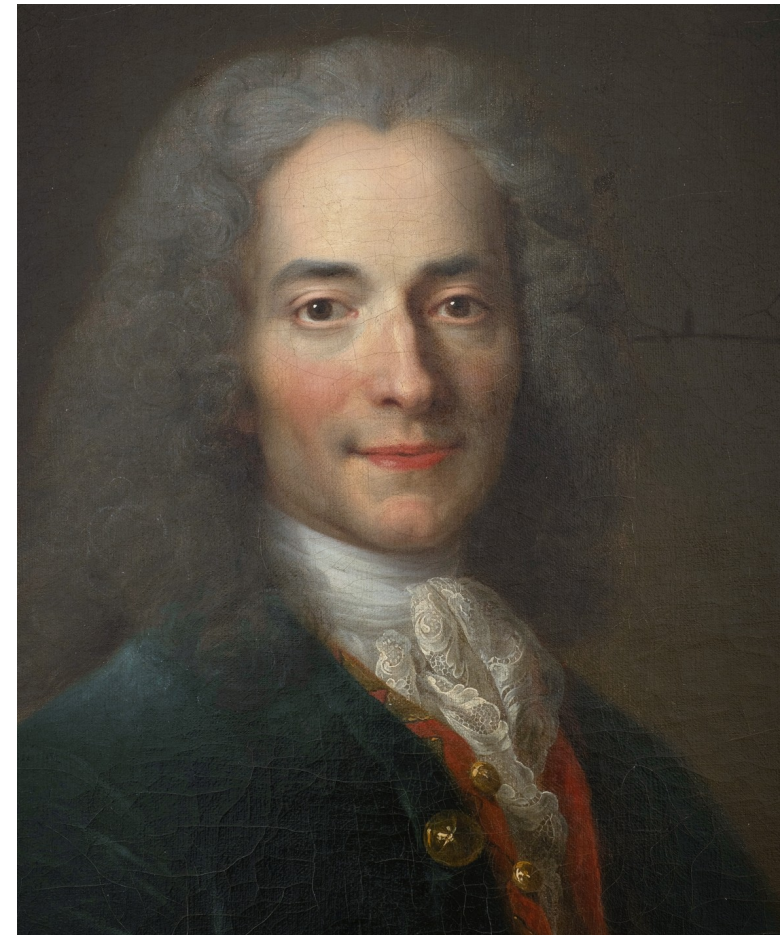
- ## ➤ **Socrates' Martyrdom :** Tried and executed for "corrupting the youth," his death underscores both the power and peril of free expression.



La Mort de Socrate by Jacques-Louis David

Age of Enlightenment

- **Enlightenment Thinkers:** Philosophers like John Locke and Voltaire argued that free expression is a natural right essential to human dignity and social progress.
- **Echoed in “Liberté, Égalité, Fraternité”:**
- ❖ **Liberté:** Guarantees the individual’s liberty to express opinions and criticize authority.



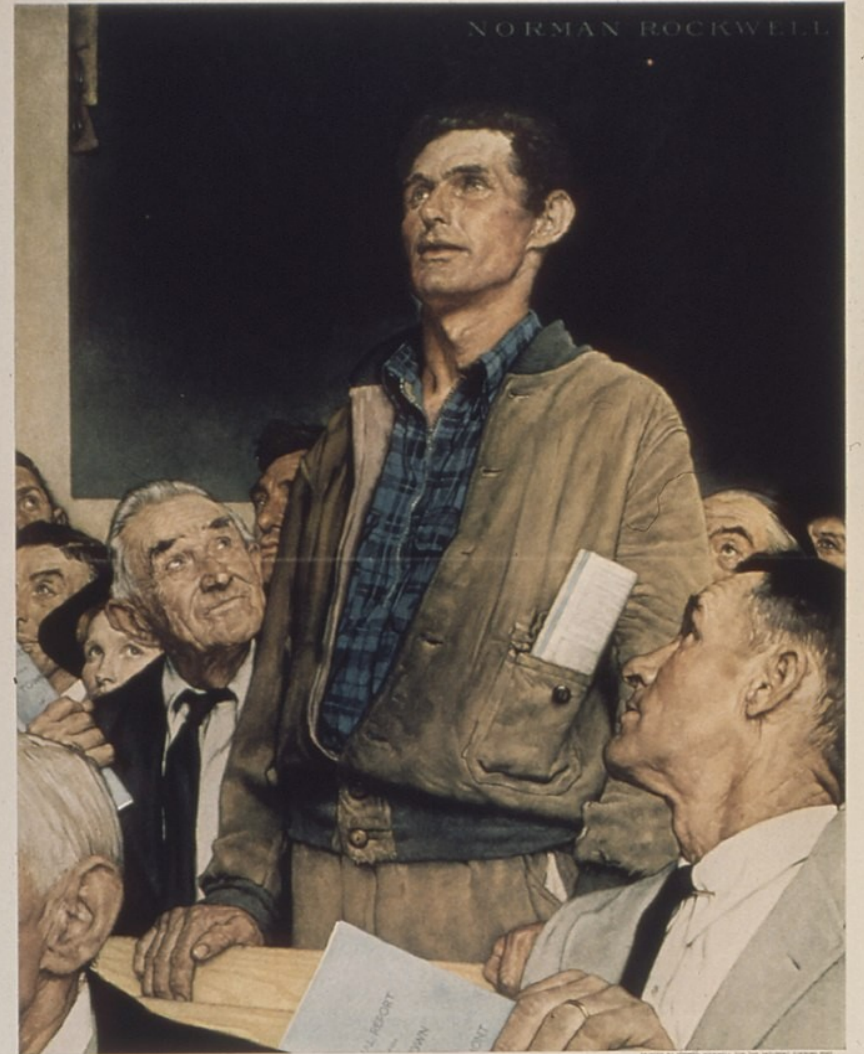
Voltaire

Laws

UDHR: Everyone has the right to freedom of opinion and expression; this right includes freedom to hold opinions without interference.

Pakistan: Every citizen shall have the right to freedom of speech and expression, and there shall be freedom of the press, subject to any reasonable restrictions.

Freedom of Speech by Norman Rockwell



Freedom of Speech

Why It Still Matters Today?

- Because other voices matter—freedom of speech gives everyone a seat at the table.
- Because silence enables oppression—free speech is how people stand up without violence.



The Flower and the Bayonet by Marc Riboud



What would our world look like
without the right to speak?



Drawing the Line

Constitution – Freedom?

- The Constitution guarantees freedom of speech and expression — but not without conditions
- It permits “**reasonable restrictions**” for Islam’s glory, national security, public order, morality, or decency
- These vague terms give the authorities power to silence what it sees as “anti-state” or “offensive”.



Vague Laws, Real Consequences

v Laws open to misuse:

- **PECA 2016**: Blocks or punishes online speech under unclear terms like "anti-national".
- **PPC 153-A / 295-C**: Target activists or dissenting voices through allegations of hate or blasphemy.
- ❖ Laws rarely used against hate groups—but often applied to journalists, students, and protesters.



Black mirror

When Protest Becomes a Crime



Students, activists, and human rights defenders are often branded as “anti-national” — not for breaking laws, but for **demanding justice, equality, and accountability.**



Activists fighting for unprivileged communities face **coordinated online hate campaigns** and **state-backed narratives** that aim to discredit their peaceful movements by labeling them “foreign-funded.”

The Chilling Effect

- **Student unions, academic forums, and media outlets** once shaped national discourse—many are now dismantled, defunded, or tightly controlled.
- **Cultural expression suffers too**—filmmakers, artists, and playwrights are discouraged from tackling social or political themes.
- Like **Iran's moral police**, authorities can act without limits when “morality” is vaguely defined—turning personal values into tools of state control.





What happens when speech isn't
just suppressed—but turns
hateful?



When Speech Turns Toxic

Definition:

- Ø **Speech that incites hatred, violence, or discrimination** against a group based on race, religion, ethnicity, gender, or identity.
- **Hate speech ≠ unpopular opinion:**
It aims to **dehumanize or endanger**, not debate or dissent.



From Words to Violence

- **Hate speech doesn't stay online** — it spreads fear, deepens division, and can lead to **mob violence, riots, and targeted killings**.
- Algorithms reward outrage and sensationalism, giving hate speech **speed, reach, and immunity**.

"Social media gives legions of idiots the right to speak... now they have the same right to speak as a Nobel Prize winner. It's the invasion of the idiots."

— Umberto Eco

Pakistan – Real Consequences

- **Religious minorities are frequent targets:**
Hate sermons, social media abuse, and public accusations against **Christians, Ahmadis, Shias, and Hindus** fuel fear and division.
- **Blasphemy accusations can be fatal:**
One online post—or even a rumor—can trigger **mob violence** before any trial.
- *Mashal Khan*, a university student **lynched over a false blasphemy accusation** in 2017.



Drawing the Line

- Not all offensive speech is hate speech — but when words incite violence, discrimination, or hostility, they cross the line.

- Civic responsibility means speaking with purpose, not with prejudice.

The UN Rabat Plan also recommends limiting speech only if it's a clear, intentional incitement to harm — not just disagreement or criticism.

- The goal is to **protect speech that challenges**, not speech that destroys.





As citizens, how do we protect
freedom of expression—while also
protecting each other from harm?



From Bystanders to Builders

Awareness Begins with Us

A Failed Translation by Zhu Gaocanyue

- **Silence helps hate grow** — if we don't speak up against harmful speech, we allow it to become normal.

"I raise up my voice — not so I can shout, but so that those without a voice can be heard."

~**Malala Yousafzai**

- **Start conversations** — in classrooms, homes, and online — about the real meaning of freedom of expression.



Digital Literacy Is Civic Power

- Teach people how to **recognize fake news, spot hate-filled content**, and report online abuse.
- Especially important in an age where social media manipulates emotions and spreads disinformation.
- Promote **critical thinking online** — don't believe or share everything you see.



Engagement Through Action

- **Host open forums, workshops, and safe discussion spaces** in schools, colleges, and communities to build a culture of **listening and learning**.
- **Launch social media campaigns** that celebrate **inclusivity, civic values, and responsible speech** — like #SpeakWithRespect or #VoicesNotViolence.
- **Collaborate with educators, youth leaders, and local groups** to bring awareness beyond campuses.



Lead By Example

- **We must live the values we promote:**
Listen with empathy. Disagree with respect. Speak with courage — and kindness.
- **Freedom of speech is not just a right — it's a civic duty.**
Let's use our voices to **amplify truth, protect the vulnerable, and build bridges, not walls.**
- Real change starts **not with laws**, but with how **we choose to speak and respond every day.**





What if the real test of free speech
isn't what we say — but how we
choose to respond when others
speak?



Thank You